

Getting Ready for Your Sixth Guided AI Session

A short guide to read before you begin

This guide explains what will happen in your sixth session with the AI assistant. Reading it first means you'll know what to expect, why the session is shaped the way it is, and how to get the most out of it. It takes just a few minutes to read.

Welcome back — from understanding to doing

So far, your sessions have been about seeing clearly. You looked at how a situation sparks an automatic thought, how the thought stirs an emotion, and how that emotion shapes what you do and how your body reacts — all looping back on itself. You mapped the bigger picture of the problems you'd like to be free from and the goals you'd like to move toward. And you practised turning a single troubling thought over slowly and fairly.

This session takes a gentle step from understanding into doing. Many of the problems we carry are kept alive by the things we quietly avoid — places we don't go, actions we don't take, words we don't say. Avoiding them brings quick relief, which is exactly why the habit sticks. This session introduces a friendly, well-tested way to turn that around: you'll make a list of the situations you find hard, sort them by how difficult they feel, and begin approaching the manageable ones — a little at a time, in an order you choose, and never faster than feels right.

Good to know: There are no right or wrong answers here, and nothing you say is being graded. The whole method is built around what you can manage — you will never be asked to face something that feels impossible. The hard parts are shared with your therapist, not handed to you to face alone.

What this session is

You'll work through one main tool with the AI guide: the **Color-Coded Symptom Hierarchy (CCSH)** — a simple way of listing the situations you find difficult and giving each one a score from 0 to 5, where every number also has a colour. Those colours do something important: they separate the situations worth practising on your own from the ones best faced with your therapist beside you.

Along the way you'll also look at two things that make the practice work: *how* facing a difficult situation actually settles the fear over time, and the small, easy-to-miss habits — we'll call them **safety behaviours** — that bring quick relief but quietly keep the difficulty alive.

Who you'll be talking to

As before, you'll be chatting with an AI assistant set up to guide this one exercise — a friendly companion for this particular step. A few things to keep in mind:

- It is **not a replacement** for your therapist or doctor. It's guiding one exercise, not managing your overall care.
- It won't push you into anything. In particular, it will **never** ask you to face the most distressing items on your list by yourself — those belong to the work you do with your therapist.
- It won't tell you what your scores "should" be. The scores are always yours.

- It stays gently focused on this exercise. If you raise something else, it will kindly keep to the task and suggest saving that for your therapist.

How the session will flow

The session moves through a clear, unhurried sequence. You don't need to memorise it — the AI leads the way — but here's the shape, so nothing feels out of the blue.

Part 1 — Your list of difficult situations

First, the guide will help you name the situations or actions you find hard to do, or tend to avoid. It's fine to have only one or two big ones — a work meeting, a particular errand, holding a certain object. Most people do. When that happens, you won't be pushed to invent new problems; instead you'll gently explore the different versions of the situation you already named, because the difficulty often changes with the details.

For example, a meeting might feel one way with your own team and quite another with senior colleagues; presenting familiar material is not the same as unfamiliar material; doing something alone differs from doing it with someone there; and one particular person's presence can change everything. Each of these can become its own small item.

A helpful way to phrase things: Keep each item small, concrete, and about something you can actually do — "say one sentence in Monday's meeting," rather than something large and vague like "stop being anxious." Small and specific is exactly what makes an item workable. And every little thing you do to feel safe can become an item simply by turning it around: "I sit far from the person leading" becomes "sit a little closer next time."

Part 2 — Scoring with the colours

Next, you'll give each situation a score from 0 to 5 using the colour-coded scale below. Before scoring anything difficult, the guide will warm up with something easy — usually, "How does it feel to be talking with me right now?" — so the low end of the scale has a clear anchor.

The Color-Coded Symptom Scale

0	Comfortable or indifferent	] Not a concern <i>you can rest here</i>
1	Slightly uncomfortable	
2	Uncomfortable	] Discomfort <i>worth practising</i>
3	Very uncomfortable	
4	So distressing I face it only if I really must	] Distress <i>with your therapist</i>
5	So distressing I can't imagine facing it	

About those colours: The blues (0–1) are situations you can rest easy with. The greens (2–3) mark discomfort — the kind of hard that's worth leaning into, and these become your practice items. The yellow (4) and red (5) mark distress — and here's the reassuring part: these are not yours to force. They're worked through together with your therapist, and they tend to soften and move down the scale as therapy goes on.

Part 3 — Discomfort versus distress

This is the heart of the session. There's a real difference between discomfort and distress, and the whole method rests on it.

Green **discomfort** is the ordinary hard that's worth doing — like the effort of going to work on a tired morning, keeping to a plan, exercising when you'd rather not, or studying for something you want. You already tolerate discomfort like this every day, for things you value. The green items on your list are no different: uncomfortable, but within reach, and good for you.

Yellow and red **distress** is a different thing entirely — and that's precisely where you get help rather than going it alone.

The idea underneath it all: No one reaches health — of body, mind, or life — without tolerating some discomfort along the way. Rather than being told this, you'll be asked about your own life until the point makes itself. The guide will help you find an everyday example that genuinely fits you (and will steer clear of using "work" as the example if work is part of what's hard).

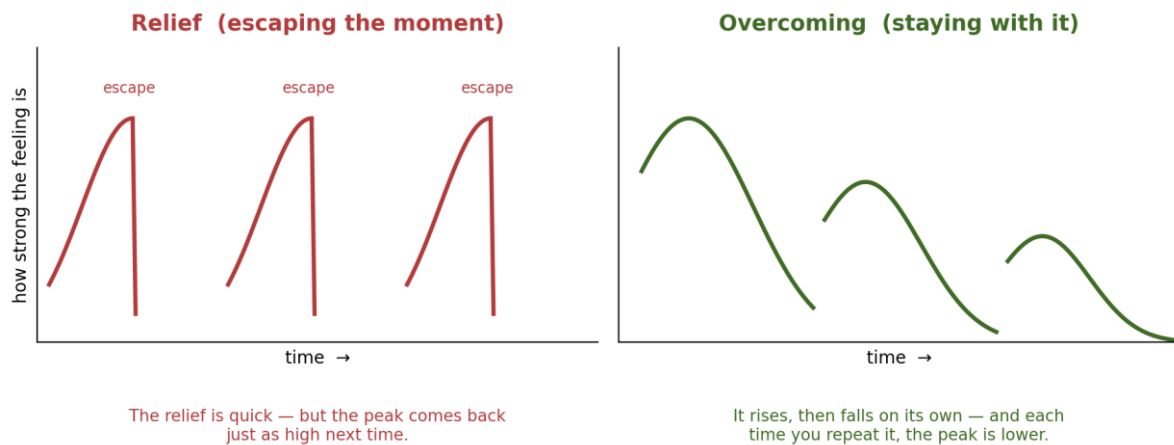
Part 4 — Choosing what to practise, and how facing things works

Together, you'll choose two or three green items to practise before your next session — you pick them; they're never imposed. This comes with a gentle, two-sided agreement: you take on the green items, and your therapist takes on the yellow and red ones, and will never ask you to face a red item alone. That balance is what makes the whole thing fair.

Then the guide will explain, in plain terms, why gently facing a situation works — resting on three simple ideas:

- **Intensity** — the work always stays within what you can handle. You'll never be asked to do the impossible.
- **Duration** — if you stay with a situation long enough instead of leaving at the worst moment, the feeling tends to ease on its own.
- **Frequency** — one go is never enough. Repeating it is what lets the fear settle for good.

The picture below shows why this matters — the difference between escaping a moment and staying with it:



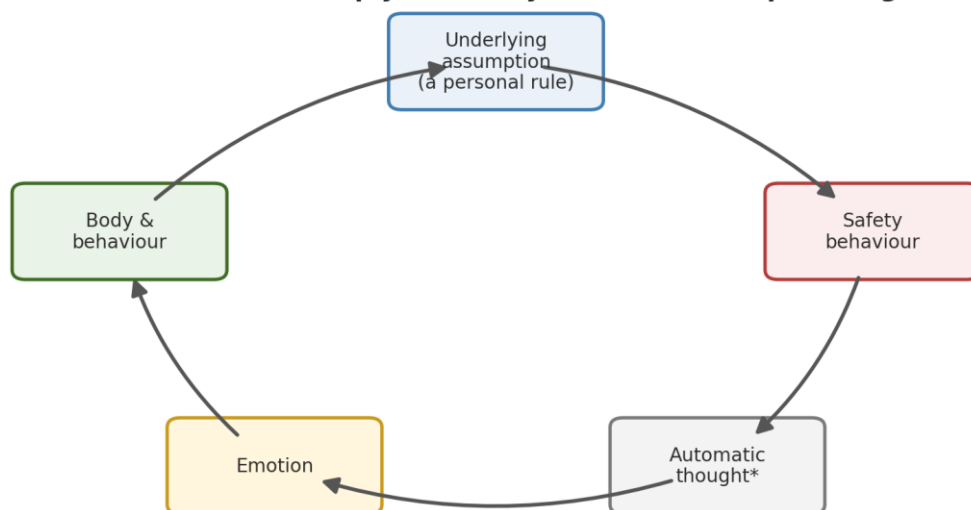
Relief versus overcoming. Escaping brings the feeling down fast, but it returns just as strongly next time; staying with it lets the feeling rise, settle, and fade — a little lower each time you repeat it. Copyright: Irismar Reis de Oliveira; trial-basedcognitivetherapy.com.

Finally, you'll think about who could help you follow through — a friend, partner, or colleague who might check in — and a simple back-up plan in case the chance to practise doesn't come up as expected. A commitment with someone behind it, and a plan B, tends to survive contact with a busy week.

Part 5 — Seeing the cycle behind it

Toward the end, the guide will show you the small cycle that keeps a difficulty going, called **Circuit 2**. This is where the term *safety behaviour* is introduced properly: the little things we do to feel safe — going quiet, sitting far away, avoiding an object, checking, reassuring ourselves. They bring quick relief, but that relief is exactly what keeps the loop turning, and it quietly stops us from ever finding out what would really happen.

Circuit 2 — the loop your safety behaviours keep turning



**The automatic thought may be quiet, quick, or not there at all.*

Circuit 2 — a personal rule leads to a safety behaviour, which (sometimes through a passing thought) feeds an emotion and a bodily reaction, which loops back and confirms the rule. Copyright: Irismar Reis de Oliveira; trial-basedcognitivetherapy.com.

You'll put your own example into this picture — the rule you live by ("If I... then...") and the safety behaviour it drives — and see how facing the green items, gently and repeatedly, is the way out of the loop. The guide won't hand you a ready-made rule to nod along to; it'll ask questions until the words are your own.

Seeing your progress over time

This list isn't one-and-done. Every so often you'll score the same items again, and the numbers — and their colours — will shift. That's the whole point: to make your progress visible, even when it happens slowly. Over the weeks, the aim is to watch reds and yellows drift toward greens and blues.

reds and yellows drifting toward greens and blues →

Item	S1	S2	S3	S4	S5
Go to the supermarket	5	5	4	3	2
Touch a door handle	5	4	4	3	2
Say a word that scares me	4	4	3	2	1
Take the escalator	5	5	4	4	3
Prepare food for others	5	4	3	2	2
TOTAL	24	22	18	14	10

A sample tracking sheet across several sessions, with a few example items. Your own sheet will be in your words, and your own colours will move at their own pace.

What the conversation will feel like

- **Lots of gentle questions.** The guide leads mostly by asking, not lecturing. The insights land better when they're yours.
- **One thing at a time.** It works through one situation before moving to the next, so nothing piles up.
- **Unhurried.** There's no clock, and no need to have polished answers ready.
- **Okay to be unsure.** If a score feels like it's between two numbers, just say so — the guide will help you weigh them.
- **Conversational.** It's meant to feel like talking with a knowledgeable friend, not filling in a form.

What to have ready before you start

- **The Color-Coded Symptom Scale card.** It's printed in the Annex at the end of this guide — have it open or nearby. The guide will check you have it before the scoring begins.
- **A sense of what you tend to avoid.** You don't need a finished list; it's completely normal for items to surface as you talk.
- **Somewhere to jot things down.** Your worksheet or manual, so you can write your items and scores in your own words as you go.
- **A quiet moment.** Set aside a stretch of uninterrupted time where you can focus and reply thoughtfully.
- **An open, curious frame of mind.** You're here to look honestly at what's hard — not to judge yourself for it.

A few tips to get the most from it

- Answer honestly — the scores only reflect what you put into them, and they're for you, not for anyone to judge.

- Keep your items small and concrete. "Ask one question in the meeting" is far more workable than "be more confident."
- Remember that the green items are where the week's practice lives — the yellows and reds are your therapist's job, not homework.
- Between sessions, notice the little things you do to feel safe. Spotting them is already part of the work.

What this session is not

So there are no surprises, here's what the AI won't do:

- It won't diagnose you or manage your treatment.
- It won't provide crisis support or emergency care.
- It won't carry out deeper TBCT techniques — those are introduced by your therapist.
- It won't ask you to face distressing (yellow or red) situations on your own — ever.

If you're in distress This session is a learning exercise, not an emergency service. If at any point you feel overwhelmed, or you have thoughts of harming yourself, please pause and reach out to your study clinician or your local emergency services right away. Your safety matters more than finishing the exercise.

You don't need to prepare anything else — the AI will guide you step by step. When you're ready, begin whenever you like.

Annex

Your Color-Coded Symptom Scale

Keep this nearby during your session. You'll use it to choose a score from 0 to 5 for each situation on your list. This is exactly the wording — and the colours — your guide will use, so read it over beforehand and the numbers will feel familiar when they come up.

SCORE	WHAT IT MEANS · HOW IT'S HANDLED
0 Light blue	Facing it is comfortable, or I don't mind it. → Not a matter of concern.
1 Blue	Facing it is slightly uncomfortable. → Not a matter of concern.
2 Light green	Facing it is uncomfortable. → Discomfort — worth practising (homework or in session).
3 Dark green	Facing it is very uncomfortable. → Discomfort — worth practising (homework or in session).
4 Yellow	So distressing that I face it only if I really must. → Distress — faced with the therapist, never alone.
5 Red	So distressing that I can't imagine facing it. → Distress — never on your own; softens over time.

In a nutshell: Blue = rest easy. Green = discomfort, and worth practising. Yellow and red = distress, and always faced together with your therapist, never alone. As you work the green and yellow items, the reds tend to become yellows and the yellows greens — and your tracking sheet will show it.

The Circuit 2 loop, in words

If it helps to see the cycle written out, here is the chain your guide will walk through with your own example in it:

**Underlying assumption → Safety behaviour → [Automatic thought]* → Emotion → Body & behaviour
→ Underlying assumption**

**The automatic thought may be quiet, quick, or not there at all.*

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